

2014 A LEVEL PAPER 2 ANSWER SCHEME

1. What are the purposes of the author's opening question? [2]

Inferred	
	1: Introduces/contextualises the topic of the passage which focuses on the relationship between the past and the present / how the past is useful in understanding the present 2: Rhetorical question that leads the reader to reflect on how often the link between the past and present is made 3: To gain consensus from the reader with the use of the personal pronoun "we". <i>3 purposes – 2 marks</i> <i>1-2 purposes – 1 mark</i>

2. In lines 2-4, what similarity does the author see between the effects of the invention of the printing press and the development of the internet? **Use your own words as far as possible.** [1]

Lifted	Paraphrased
...a look back at the turmoil created by the invention of mechanical printing in Europe, nearly six centuries ago, does indeed reveal parallels with the equally seismic effects of today's revolution in communications.	Both the invention of the printing press and the development of the internet resulted in great chaos/great unrest/ huge furore. <i>*Degree of intensity needs to be reflected. DO NOT accept "caused problems" as this phrase do not capture the degree of intensity.</i>

3. Explain what the author means by describing what has happened to English on the web as "the converse" (line 30) of what happened to Latin. **Use your own words as far as possible.** [1]

Lift	Paraphrase
... new texts were often produced in contemporary languages, which <i>fatally undermined</i> the primacy of Latin as the language of medieval intellectual discourse. Today, the <i>burgeoning use</i> of English on the web shows the <i>converse of that decline</i> . (lines 27-30)	The fate of Latin and English are markedly different in that the use of Latin was <u>gravely / terminally / severely / critically / very seriously reduced / curtailed / challenged / destabilised</u>, While English's <u>role rises to prominence / proliferated / thrived / increased substantially / multiplied tremendously</u>. <i>Both aspects for 1m</i> <i>Note: It is <u>not</u> that the spread of English is being achieved at the expense of Latin.</i>

4. In paragraph 5, what parallels does the author draw between the consequences for authors of the printing revolution and contributors to today's Internet? **Use your own words as far as possible.**

[3]

Lift	Paraphrased
...this new found benefit was <u>then itself</u> threatened by the <u>rise of piracy ... producing unauthorised copies of popular editions</u> ... (lines 35-36)	<i>Answers are to be phrased in pairs...</i> Authors from the past were <u>vulnerable and exposed to their works being reproduced without permission</u> ,
... precursors of <u>modern-day illegal downloads</u> . (lines 36-37)	Similarly, present-day authors have their <u>works copied/transferred from the Internet unlawfully</u> .
It took <u>three hundred years</u> before any kind of copyright system <u>attempted to safeguard</u> the financial interests of writers and publishers (lines 37-38) ... a system which <u>today struggles to keep pace with the ever-changing ramifications of what is possible on the net</u> . (lines 39-40)	In the past, it took a very long time to come up with a system to protect the interests of the authors. This highlights <u>the difficulty they faced</u> then... Similarly, the system today <u>faces challenges and difficulties</u> in protecting the content of the authors.
... content of some printed texts was <u>erroneous, deluded, trivial, offensive or malicious</u> ... (lines 40-41) Some authors, rather than enjoying wealth, suffered prosecution. (lines 41 to 42)	Like the current online content, books in the past had <u>mistakes, wrong, false, insignificant or distasteful information</u> . Hence, authors in the past and present would be subjected to oppression/ vilification/ harsh treatments.

5. In what ways does the author consider the internet “preferable” to television in lines 52-54? **Use your own words as far as possible.**

[2]

Text	Paraphrased
Active participation and collaboration with others are crucial – preferable, surely to being the lone passive consumers we are with television, which was once just as vilified by scaremongers as the internet is now.	A (active participation + collaboration): The internet offers opportunities for users to engage and work with others B (lone + passive): while the television only allows individuals to absorb or receive information on their own in a mindless/ unquestioning manner. <i>Answers should provide appropriate signpost to show contrast.</i>

6. Explain the author's use of the word "very" in line 59.

[1]

Text	Inferred
"...that the internet's very speed and accessibility lead to over-hasty actions, without due reflection and consideration of possible consequences."	A (function): To highlight the quality of the internet as being extremely fast and easily available, B (context): and that ironically this speed is a double-edged sword which enables efficiency, while causing us to make impulsive decisions without deliberation.

7. In lines 61-66, what does the author suggest are the educational and personal consequences for those who "skim rather than delve"? **Use your own words as far as possible.** [2m]

Lifted	Paraphrased
In addition, critics argue that it is creating a generation who skim rather than delve, who click from source to source without real engagement with content and the attendant consolidation of knowledge. Equally superficial, some claim, are the connections with others. <u>Instead</u> of face-to-face encounters and true friendships built on ties of trust, responsibility and give-and-take, so-called friends are now amassed in on-line networks and just as easily disposed of.	Educational consequences for these individuals are: A1: that they read without truly understanding the context/ meaning/ without engaging the meaning of the texts. A2:and without synthesizing/ organising the information into a useful body of knowledge [1m for A1+A2] Personal consequences are: B1:that their relationships tend to be shallow, B2:impersonal, B3:fake/not genuine/ not authentic B4:and not enduring [1m for any 1 from B1-4]

8. In paragraph 8, the author claims that "technological advance is always made at the cost of previous behaviours or dearly held principles". How does the remainder of the paragraph illustrate her assertion? **Use your own words as far as possible.** [2m]

Lifted	Paraphrased
Consider privacy, for example: previous notions of guardedness are disregarded by those members of social networking sites or purchasers of on-line services who readily volunteer personal information which is then indelibly stored and traceable. This new attitude to privacy was articulated - even encouraged - by the CEO of a major computing company who glibly but presciently said, "You have zero privacy. Get over it." - and that was back in 1999!	A:The remainder of the paragraph illustrates how with technological advances in info-communication, social media users or purchasers of online services esteem privacy less/ dismiss important privacy or security issues B:and willingly/promptly reveal details of their personal life without thinking of the consequences/ even though these would be permanently recorded and linked back to them. [1 pt = 1m]

9. In lines 78 – 81, how confident is the author about future use of the internet by the young? **Use your own words as far as possible.** [2m]

Lifted	Paraphrased
The young - ... - have always sought spaces beyond adult supervision but most, surely, will have the sense to control rather than be controlled.	The author is optimistically confident that 1. as the young have always found avenues to explore the use of the internet by themselves, 2. majority of them will be able to manage it / use it to their advantage 3. and will certainly not succumb to its influence / be addicted to it / be enslaved to it. 1-2 points - 1 mark 3 points - 2 marks

10. How does the quotation from Zhou Enlai (lines 83 – 84) support the author’s argument earlier in this paragraph? **Use your own words as far as possible.** [1m]

Lifted	Paraphrased
The challenge for society will be how to develop awareness of the benefit and potential pitfalls of a digital age. ... As for the final verdict on the internet, we are too close to its inception to have any meaningful perspective. It is rather like when Zhou Enlai was asked what he thought were the effects of the French Revolution two centuries earlier and he replied, “It is too soon to say”.	It supports the author’s argument that the effects of the digital age are still unfolding / the true effects are yet to be manifested / it is premature to tell what the effects of the digital age are.

11. Using material from paragraphs 2 – 4 only (lines 5-32), summarise what the author has to say about the changes to book production brought about by the invention of the printing press. Write your summary in no more than 120 words, not counting the opening words which are printed below. Use your own words as far as possible.

Paragraph 2

Line	Point	Lift (Before)	Lift (After)	Paraphrase	Main idea
11	1		As a result of this first assembly-line method of production	standardised process to put a book together	Mechanisation helped in mass production of books
11	2		copies were now uniformly duplicated	identical books could be printed /reproduced	Reproduced identically
11	3		... in hitherto undreamed-of numbers	In amounts never imagined / in large quantities (BOD)	In Imaginarily large numbers
12	4		Books became more portable ...	People could carry them around more easily / books became more mobile /were easily carried about	more convenient to carry books around
12	5		Durable	long-lasting / robust / hard-wearing / sturdy	books became sturdier
12	6		Affordable	cheap/inexpensive	Cheap
13	7		Reaching an ever-expanding audience	Books could reach a growing /increasingly wider audience / there is widespread readership / spread quickly	Reach a growing audience

Paragraph 3

Line	Point	Lift (Before)	Lift (After)	Paraphrase	Main idea
15	8		Sudden availability of multiple copies led to the dissemination of the existing ones	Many/numerous reprints were then freely / widely distributed	Freely / widely distributed
16	9	These volumes had been scattered		Books could be easily assembled together in one place	Easy Assembly
	10		Possible to read all that had been written on any subject	Access to all subject-related knowledge	Easy access to knowledge
19	11		Could spot errors and disagreements	Notice /observe/identify/locate mistakes and inconsistencies / discrepancies	Easy to spot errors
19	12		Created scepticism	Gave rise to doubt/suspicion	Doubt
20	13		And rejection of	Non-acceptance/dismissal/refusal	Refusal
20	14		Previously unquestioned schools of thought	of assumptions of past beliefs / theories / philosophies	Of fallacious beliefs
21	15		Allowing for synthesis and	Gave rise to the combination /amalgamation / integration and	Result in synthesis
21	16		the formulation of new theories	Development/conception/creation of new / novel theories	and creation of new ones

Paragraph 4

Line	Point	Lift (Before)	Lift (After)	Paraphrase	Main idea
23	17		The new medium include supporting illustration	enhanced with relevant / related / visuals	Supporting visuals
25	18		New texts by living authors now proliferated	Current writings can now be widely distributed	New books widely spread
25	19		Bringing into circulation new ideas	propagating novel / original ideas and	With their novel ideas
26	20		Which proved impossible to suppress completely	Which were not possible to stop / curb completely	Impossible to curb
27	21		New texts were often produced in contemporary languages	Modern languages replaced the traditional languages / Latin	Modern languages replacement
31	22		Keep abreast of new religious and scientific thinking	Keeping up with / Staying ahead of the prevailing religious and scientific beliefs/ ideas/theories	Keeping up-to-date with scientific developments
31	23		And then to contribute in print to such debates	allows for participation of such discussions in print	Participation in discussion
32	24		Future editions were corrected	Reprints / Revisions could capture greater accuracy	Accurate future editions
33	25		Thus creating a new culture of feedback	Fostering / encouraging constructive criticism / comments	Encouraging critical comments

After the invention of the printing press, books could be efficiently (1) and consistently (2) published. Mass-produced (3), they became mobile (4), sturdy (5) and inexpensive (6), drawing wider readership (7). With numerous reprints (8), books which were once inaccessible are now available (9), where one could access extensive coverage on any topic (10). This makes it easier to notice inaccuracies and inconsistencies (11), triggering scepticism (12) and the dismissal (13) of conventional theories. (14) The process of refining ideas gave rise to the amalgamation (15) and creation of new knowledge (16). Books were enhanced with visuals (17). Also, contemporary works could be widely distributed, (18) propagating novel ideas, (19) making it difficult to curb information (20). Books were published in modern languages (21) and people could update themselves on the latest thinking, (22) which drew discussion in print (23). Finally, reprints were edited for greater accuracy, (24) encouraging constructive criticism. (25)

(120 words)

Application Question

12. Emily Speight generally welcomes the internet but highlights some concerns about its possible effects on individuals and society. How far would you agree with her observations, both for and against the internet, relating your arguments to your own society?

Author's point	Explanation	Agree	Disagree
Facilitated an explosion in the material available and an increased ease of access to it (lines 45-46)	Over the years the internet has begun to be the repository of all kinds of information. The ease with which a layman can access this information is also phenomenal. People also put out all kinds of information on their own to be shared. And this is more than anything ever seen in all the years of human development.	EX: There is an astronomical amount of information that is available and recordable via the internet. There are several websites for news, and commentary that complement and substitute the mainstream media like Stomp, TR Emeritus, The Real Singapore, Mr Brown, and The Independent. These provide alternative news sites. There are also thousands of websites that provide business news, social news and entertainment and other information at the fingertips. Singaporeans can be seen accessing these sites all the time. From Facebook to Instagram to other applications for taxi and bus services, Singaporeans use their smartphones to find the information instantly. They have become very dependent on the information provided by the internet on their phone. They are so dependent that now they cannot live without the phone. Every conceivable application is on the phone. EV: All these examples tell the same story: that the world contains an unimaginably vast amount of digital information which is getting ever vaster, ever more rapidly. This makes it possible to do many things that previously could not be done: spot business trends, prevent diseases, combat crime and so on. Managed well, the data can be used to unlock new sources of economic value, provide fresh insights into science and hold governments to account. The extensive use of social media by politicians in Singapore in the recent lead up to the next General Elections (GE) is a case in point demonstrating to how the internet is fully being utilised to convey key campaign messages to the people, as well as for the people to find out more about the candidates before casting their votes. Transparency between government agencies and the people is also enhanced with the use of the internet as seen evidently in the Attorney General's Chamber (AGC)'s online publication of the Public Prosecutor's Skeletal Submissions against teenager Amos Yee for making vile remarks on Christianity and on the People's Action Party.	Despite the great convenience in sharing information via the internet, this convenience also comes with a host of problems. In particular, ensuring data security and protecting privacy is becoming harder as the information multiplies and is shared ever more widely around the world. More functions mean more protection is needed. There have been cases of Phishing for information and hacking which has put people's information at risk. For this reason, the Media Development Authority (MDA) in Singapore is constantly monitoring the usage of the internet so that Singaporeans can use it responsibly.

Creation of a culture of connectedness and empowerment, where one can communicate with family, friends and peers unconstrained by time or distance (lines 47-48)	There is a new way of communicating with family and friends and peers even in Singapore that has never been so. Although Singapore is a small place, Singaporeans are very busy people and do not have the time to catch up with each other. Now internet has brought all these people together.	Singapore has 4.4 million internet users. Apart from the Scandinavian countries, Singapore has the highest mobile broadband penetration in Asia (123% according to ITU World Telecommunications) since almost all Singaporeans have smart handphones and so they do not even need to communicate through the internet on their computers. They use their smartphones or tablets to communicate. There are several means Singaporeans communicate with each other. Besides being able to call on the phone anytime, most people keep in touch via 'Whatspp' on a daily basis. Platforms like Facebook, Instagram, Messenger and other applications that abound are commonly used. They may do it singly or be part of a group, and it could be group of family members, friends or peers. One can communicate to more than one group at one time wherever they are in the world. This has empowered them to voice their opinion and to articulate their suggestions confidently. It allows them to distance themselves from those they do not like and allows them to keep in close touch with those they like. They are communicating more since they can avoid face to face interaction. Many find the impersonal way of communicating and keeping in touch easier. Though such forms of communication may seem superficial, it is still by far still better than not communicating at all.	It can be said that we have come to be very dependent on the phone. It is also said that we have become a very impersonal community. There is very little face-to-face interactions. Everyone is caught up using their phones. Even when family members of friends gather, all of them appear to be looking at their phones and there is a tendency to avoid social interaction as they find greater comfort in occupying themselves with their phones. . So the true meaning of interaction is lost.
Extension of our social lives, not a virtual replacement of them, because it leads to increased interaction (vs television) (lines 50-54)	The internet provides additional avenues for us to communicate other than in a face to face manner. This has not in any way removed the desire for nor the importance of face to face communication.	Due to its speed and reach, the internet has enhanced our ability to connect and remain connected to many people at any given time and in real time. The internet has therefore made communication easier, immediate, unfettered, more frequent, more efficient and unconstrained by distance. It has therefore added to and enhanced the range and depth of our relationships - our connectedness to and intimacy with others. Specifically, • We are able to reach a larger social network thru this online means than we would ordinarily have been able to do through the conventional methods of meeting solely at social events. • We meet a broader range of people and maintain relationships with family and friends in different	Yet, the internet has in some way facilitated a decline in the depth of communication as we sacrifice that for function - the immediacy and ease of communication. We have become very adept and focussed on short, sharp and quick messages and are distracted by handling many different conversations at one time. In many situations, we have favoured this form of communication and have been deluded into believing that the frequency of short interactions allows us to develop and maintain a deep level of relationship. In so doing, we have diminished our ability to be focussed and engaged, to practice active, empathetic listening and meaningful communication.

		countries. • We are in touch with thoughts/feelings of those whom we know/work with throughout the day and we are able to participate in several discussions at the same time while on the go. • Social networking sites can be brilliant, particularly for children with autism, dyslexia and dyspraxia, who can struggle to form friendships. It would be expected that this ease would take away from or diminish actual face-to-face interaction between individuals. Yet, there has not been a corresponding or expected decline in the conventional interactions/social relationships. In Singapore, while there is a very high participation rate on Facebook, Twitter and other social websites, there are certainly no signs to show that it has led to a decline in the need to gather and to communicate on a social level as well. Social gatherings in homes and dining at restaurants/cafes are just as popular (and as trendy) as interacting online. Party catering businesses, restaurants and cafes are still doing brisk business here as they are booked solid or packed out throughout the week. It has become very much a part of our culture to go out and spend time with friends at the latest restaurant/night spot. In addition, more families are spending time together taking advantage of the parks/green spaces in the evenings/on weekends. Singaporeans still, as with everyone else worldwide, see their interactions online as a way to interact when messages need to be relayed instantly and quickly. They still consider their needs for relationship, bonding and intimacy to be better served in a face to face manner.	In some way, the idea that the internet could create a friendlier, interconnected world is flawed. The depth of a person's social network outside Facebook is what determines the depth of one's social network on social media sites, not the other way around. For the most part, Facebook does not destroy friendships—but it does not create them, either. Like any tool, its effectiveness is dependent on its user. In Singapore, this is clearly seen in the interactions between parents and children where it seems that the internet has become the preferred mode of communication which has reduced/destroyed the need for extended meaningful discussions over the dinner table. The byte sized pieces of news/information shared over the course of the day has replaced real intimacy/communication. A quite common observation here in Singapore is where family members are engaged with others or playing internet games (on their devices) even as they are supposed to be enjoying one another's company over a meal. There is little disclosure that comes from a heart to heart face to face talk.. Very often, parents do not really know who their children's friends are or what they are viewing, reading or discussing online. Some parents have had to resort to becoming 'friends' with their children on Facebook to keep tabs on who their friends are and what interests them.
Enslavement.... (i) Creating unhealthy addictions (ii) Online retailers seek to shape		It is indeed true, as Speight suggests, that we have become entangled in a web of malicious content that the internet has spun for us. The online world is teeming with danger at every turn-pornography, online gambling, and cyberbullies to name but a few and Singapore has not completely evaded these threats. In 2013, a Touch Cyber Wellness survey of 1,900	While it may seem that the internet does sometimes appeal to the worst of our inclinations, one cannot simply ignore the positive effects that the worldwide web has had. Speight claims that online retailers are out to dupe customers into buying what they suggest rather than to encourage exploration and

and exploit our tastes by suggesting what we would like rather than facilitating experimentation and happy discovery (iii) Much of the material available is unreliable and inappropriate (iv) The internet's very speed and accessibility lead to over-hasty actions without due reflection and consideration of possible consequences (v) Caters to the base in human nature (lines 56-61)		primary school students and 3,000 secondary school pupils revealed that 1 in 3 of the latter population had been bullied online, while 1 in 4 surveyed admitted to having bullied their peers in the online sphere through social networks. Furthermore, one in two teenagers in Singapore has watched or read sexually explicit materials - some as young as seven when they were first exposed to it. One in three admitted to viewing pornography in the past year, whether intentional or accidental. Experts agree that one important reason for this trend is that pornography is readily accessible on mobile devices and suggest that an obsession with pornography affects young people's studies, self-esteem and interpersonal relationships. But the dark ramifications of the cyber world extend beyond just the young. The number of adults addicted to online football betting, which is illegal in Singapore, is on the rise too, according to gambling intervention groups. Two out of five cases they see are related to this. It is clear that even in Singapore, where the government actively intervenes online, the internet has fuelled addiction to a whole host of unhealthy vices proving that it indeed appeals to the darkest depths of our nature. It is also observed that material available online is unreliable and inappropriate. In 2015, a student posted a fabricated PMO press statement on Mr Lee Kuan Yew's death. There was also much furore over the the banning of TRS for hosting inflammatory content Online retailers seek to shape and exploit our tastes by suggesting what we would like rather than facilitating experimentation and happy discovery - More than just this: Rise in online shopping scams in Singapore - Data mining and targeted advertising by Google, Facebook etc. The internet's very speed and accessibility lead to over-hasty actions without due reflection and consideration of possible consequences. Some examples include: - Keyboard warriors, flaming & trolling	experimentation. While there are some retailers out there who suggest options for customers, one would be hard pressed to argue that they are exploitative. Popular online shopping sites such as ASOS and Zalora offer a wide array of fashion choices that actually encourages experimentation and discovery. These sites do offer discounts and promotions for customers through constant email updates. However, these updates can be turned off if the customer finds them annoying or "exploitative". Most young people in my society find the updates from these services quite useful in tracking current fashion trends. Furthermore, there is a new wave of online retailers encouraging experimentation and exploration. For example, Singapore retailer Tate & Tonic helps customers build an individual style profile and sends them clothing that is personalised to their tastes. The clothing can even be returned for free if it is not to the customer's liking! Viewed in this light, Speight's criticism that online companies are out to manipulate and exploit customers seems harsh and undeserved. The internet's very speed and accessibility lead to over-hasty actions without due reflection and consideration of possible consequences. This may not be entirely valid as far as Singapore is concerned. This is a concerted effort by the government and the community to alleviate such problems: - Not A Keyboard Warrior Campaign - o a campaign which aims to educate young people on the perils of inappropriate Internet behaviour, as well as debunk the practice of cyber aggression as a social norm. Much of the material available is unreliable and inappropriate. Granted this to the case, there is active monitoring to prevent this problem from getting out of hand. - Note: Same examples used for the
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		- Amos Yee's rant, Wee Shu Min's elitist, uncaring face Amy Cheong's Malay Weddings, Anton Casey's public transport for the poor	corresponding point in the AGREE section above can be used to argue that in Singapore, the government regulates the internet carefully to monitor websites that are spreading damaging information, minimising the negative impact of unreliable and inappropriate material.
Creating a generation who skim rather than delve, who click from source to source without real engagement with content and the attendant consolidation of knowledge (lines 62 – 63)	The internet is responsible for grooming a generation of young people with limited attention spans when it comes to thinking about what they are reading on the internet. It has divested them of the ability to ask critical/analytical questions or to form important connections between all the information they obtain.	Young people who have and who are growing up with the internet have demonstrated low levels of reading stamina and are unable to process texts/ideas of any substantial length. They are not inclined to nor able to effectively assess the credibility of the information they gain. This is because the internet delivers a massive amount of information at the click of a button, much of it in small bytes with plenty of visuals and little incentive/space for critical reflection. The information presented seems to be very persuasive and limited in scope and relies on the motivation of the young person to read widely/consider differing perspectives. It becomes very convenient to 'cut and paste' ideas as well. Many young people have not come to the realisation that just because something is on Google, does not mean it a reliable source. There are numerous instances where students have submitted essays that contain inaccuracies from sites created by someone who is not an authority on the topic. A study by Andrew Duffy, lecturer in journalism at the Wee Kim Wee School of Communication and Information at NTU (research done with the help of Tan Liying and Larissa Ong, students at RGS) found that, in their search for information online, speed, convenience and accessibility were the most important factors among teens in Singapore. Trust and reliability were secondary. Young people have also lost the desire/patience/valuable cognitive ability to ask the deeper more critical/analytical questions that would allow them to navigate the often-murky world of internet chatrooms which they are exposed to for hours on end. Many family problems could have been	While the internet does provide the most convenient avenue for obtaining a wealth of information/ideas such that it is possible to set critical analysis aside, it is an over generalisation to state that an entire generation is incapable of engaging with content and consolidating knowledge. Most internet-savvy young people do in fact exploit the internet's vast resources to conduct in-depth research for their term papers and come up with clever and creative project ideas. Young teachers, in particular, find the Internet to be extremely useful in planning lessons and building their lesson portfolios. The web has a plethora of sites created specifically for teachers to share ideas, exchange information and documents and stimulate discussions. In addition, many in their generation have launched their own unique online businesses inspired by what they have read and seen on the internet. Many have set up forums/blogs that campaign for issues/causes close to their hearts and taken pains to include a wide range of reading material and resource for those like-minded. When young people manage an online presence, they have to develop an ability to interact effectively online as it is becoming an increasingly important skill in the workplace. Being able to quickly adapt to new technologies, services and environments is regarded as a highly valuable skill by employers, and being online can facilitate both formal and informal learning of literacy skills, including interpretation, evaluation and contextualisation.

		prevented if young people would have exercised a critical ability with respect to websites promoting anorexia and self-harm. It seems that they are spurred on to greater feats of disordered eating by chatroom users who recommend “green tea and no food” for the perceived problem of a “fat back” or are tempted to experiment with drugs through websites promoting ‘skunk’ – a potent strain of cannabis that can cause psychosis.	On social networking sites, young Singaporeans take part in activities and discussions online, and showcase, upload, modify or create content (music, film, photography or writing). Young people can make informed decisions about how and what they place on a site. This can support creativity and discussions about ownership of content and data management – all these require active and critical engagement with texts which we are increasingly seeing in Singapore.
Equally superficial are the connections with others... Instead of face-to-face encounters and true friendships built on ties of trust, responsibility and give-and-take, so-called friends are now amassed in online networks and just as easily disposed of (lines 64-66)	The author acknowledges the observations of critics who claim that people are currently developing less meaningful and redundant relationships with others when they do on the internet, rather than cultivate authentic friendships based on good faith, obligations and the ability to reciprocate when they have personal interactions with one another.	The author’s observations are valid especially in the developed world which is highly dependent on the Internet for work and play, such that many ended up making shallow online contacts due to their busy lifestyle. This is applicable to Singapore, a nation of heavy users of ubiquitous smartphones and social media mobile applications, with some 87 per cent of Singaporeans using smartphones according to Nielson’s January 2014 study. There are also more than 2 million Facebook users in Singapore where almost everyone has a Facebook account (if not two or more). Those who resort to dating websites and mobile applications often find themselves building meaningless friendships with strangers. In the worst scenarios, many have fallen to scams online as they end up trusting online friends whom they hardly know. According to the Singapore Police Force, there is a rise in internet love scams as well as extortions in the first six months of 2014. At times, these online friendships seem to bond many who want to secretly report undesirable behaviour they observed in their surroundings, rather than confront the perpetrators themselves. No thanks to urban living in a highly dense city, many have distant relations with their neighbours, such that they rather share their true ill-feelings about their neighbours with the online strangers than to personally confront and	Even though the possibility of building a deep friendship appears to be better than doing so through the impersonal internet platform, the digital platform can still serve as a starting point of friendships with online friends, which will hopefully result in friendships of substance in real life as well. For example, the ubiquitous social media has served as a platform for people of similar interest groups to connect and meet up in person. Eventually, it is up to the individual how to best use the technology to discern worthy contacts from redundant ones in his online network. This is in line with the author’s views in Paragraph 9 that one has to be more self-conscious of the “benefits and pitfalls of the digital future”. This is applicable in Singapore where the social media serve as a starting point of face-to-face interactions that will hopefully result in meaningful friendships. Activists here used social media to reach out to like-minded individuals for charitable causes in the community. For instance, during a very unhealthy haze situation in 2013, haze-hero Jeremy Chua started a Facebook page calling for people to donate their excess masks and mobilised hundreds of volunteers to distribute masks to the needy.

		interact with their neighbours face to face. For example, one person secretly filmed an alleged abuse of her elderly neighbour and uploaded the video online in the hope the authorities would intervene.	
Further casualties: traditional libraries, newspapers, bookshops – even the printed book itself – will reach the end of the road first opened up by Gutenberg (lines 67-68)	The author highlights the valid concerns of critics who warn about how the growing popularity of the Internet can lead to the demise of the world of print such as the traditional libraries, newspapers, bookshops and printed books. As the Internet provides limitless content in a more visually appealing manner than the traditional print media, the threats it brings to the print media are real and warranted. The Internet could also cause the traditional library and bookshops to become irrelevant.	This is true in Singapore as educators observe fewer young adults and teenagers reading books for fun. The distraction of smartphones and more visually stimulating entertainment steer their attention away from print media. Due to the free online content available, there have been many casualties in the commercial book retail industry. It has also been a struggle for commercial bookshops to survive in Singapore and many have closed shop during last few years. Even popular chains such as Borders first closed its branch here in 2011 after its parent company REDgroup Retail in Australia had financial problems. The Borders Singapore franchise was eventually bought over by Popular Holdings, which opened a new outlet mall in 2013. In 2013, Lifestyle-cum-bookstore Prologue locally-founded bookstore Page One closed its Vivocity branch. These are serious indicators that Singaporeans are increasingly not inclined towards reading and are more enthralled by social media platforms like Instagram that offer quick visual gratification. Reading, by far, takes a lot more time for Singaporeans who are constantly complaining that we do not have enough time nor the patience to flip the pages. Cultural literacy would invariably be compromised if this trend continues in our society.	This is a somewhat overly bleak outlook about the role of print media. It still plays a role in education as studies claim that books still play a critical cognitive role in developing reading skills of children. Research at the University of Oslo suggests that reading printed pages allows the reader to synthesize and connect different pieces of information in a linear fashion, in a way that does not happen when one reads words online. Despite the massive shut-downs of commercial book chains in Singapore, the independent bookshops in Singapore have a faithful cult following thanks to the popularity of hipster cafes in certain cultural enclaves in parts of Singapore such as Tiong Bahru. Aside from benefitting from the growth of cool street culture lanes, these bookshops are very relevant to some Singapore readers as they fulfil the need to connect as well as supporting local writers who are articulating the voices of the unique Singapore identity. These small bookshops cater to the needs of a very niche community which still loves and cherishes books, literature and culture, whether it is related to local culture, or to an expatriate community whose first language is not English. They also actively organise special book events for their community of readers. Located at the Tiong Bahru are some popular indie bookshops including BookActually and the French Shop. As one of the first few independent bookshops in Singapore, BookActually specialises in local literary community. They sell a diverse range of books that

			includes independent literature and self-published titles. Its owner Kenny Leck aims to create a reading culture in Singapore. In fact this bookshop also serves the important need of promoting and supporting local poetry, fiction and anthologies. The French Bookshop offers French literature and books. Libraries here are not totally redundant as they offer a rich repository of information for the public and all. In fact, the local library evolved from being a purely traditional library to fully embracing technology and the Internet. The Singapore National Library plays an important role in curating Singapore's history and preserving Singapore's documentary heritage and collective memory for future generations; this is especially so after the National Archives of Singapore joined it in 2012. The National Library is not only one of the key partners of the Singapore Memory Project, a portal that aims to capture memories of the nation.
Consider privacy, for example: pervious notions of guardedness are disregarded by those whose members of social networking sites or purchasers of online services who readily volunteer personal information which is then indelibly stored and traceable. (lines 71-73)	Privacy is at risk as users readily give away their personal information on social media websites and online purchasing sites.	The increased popularity of social networking sites such as Twitter, Instagram and Facebook have allowed users, especially the youth to share personal information and interests among their intimate groups of friends to those from other countries. Often, personal details such as one's place of residence, school, family and friends can be easily revealed, or perhaps even intentionally revealed by some users to display their wealth or popularity. This clearly puts their privacy at risk. It can even be potentially dangerous especially if they incurred the wrath of some netizens such as in the case of Anton Casey who made disparaging remarks on the commuters and the public transport system in Singapore. Singaporeans also tend to be careless in protecting their privacy on their technological devices. According to a recent online poll by Trend Micro Incorporated by global developer of security software in 2014, almost 66 percent of respondents in Singapore are not protected on their mobile devices and personal computers. Almost half of the 750 surveyed respondents (48%) let their browser save their	Increasing numbers of Singaporeans, especially youth, do realise the dangers of revealing too much information online. A survey conducted by Singapore Polytechnic's Diploma in Media and Communication (DMC) students in 2013 indicated that while our youth are concerned with how they appear online, 94.2% of the respondents exercised caution on social media, and more than half have adjusted their privacy settings to withhold information from their social circle.

		passwords online, a dangerous practice susceptible to being hacked, especially in the wake of online data breaches. 32 percent of mobile users allow mobile apps to access their social media profiles. 77 percent of surveyed parents do not use parental control settings. 20 percent of respondents believe they have downloaded malicious apps, and 51 percent do not know if they have encountered such apps. It is clearly evident that many Singaporeans do not regard privacy as a key concern with regards to their digital use. This is perhaps due to negligent and carelessness more so than an unawareness of the dangers of the possibility of information leak.	
It is the young who are seen as at risk rather than the internet's older converts – have always sought spaces beyond adult supervision but most, surely, will have the sense to control rather than to be controlled. (lines 78-81)	At the stage of their lives where the young yearns to be free from authority and control, they are at a greater risk with regards to the perils of the Internet as compared to the older generation. Ironically, their unwillingness to be controlled will possibly give them the desire to have greater digital control.	It is indeed true that the young have taken on to the appeal of the Internet, more so than the older generation. Currently, there are more than 2.8 million Facebook users in the Singapore dominated by young adults aged 25-34, followed by the 18-24 age group. According to SocialBakers, currently, there are 2,800, 400 Facebook users in Singapore, which makes it #51 in the ranking of all Facebook statistics by Country. Another study in 2014 found that the average Singaporean youth today spend approximately 4.76 hours online on a daily basis. Citizen journalism also has a significant influence in shaping youths' views towards politics as well as their purchasing habits. Contrary to popular belief that today's youth read just about everything, a good majority of those surveyed are concerned about the credibility of what they read. Hence, the claim that they naively believe all that they read online is questionable. Almost three quarters of the group that was studied would verify on the accuracy of the content they read, of which almost half would verify if it came from a credible source. Perhaps the most interesting discovery is that about 80% of the target group still finds traditional media more competent than citizen journalism when it comes to its credibility.	Contrary to what the author argues, the young are not in greater control, but in fact may have succumbed to the dangers and temptations of the Internet. Singapore is one of the most wired places on earth: our household broadband penetration rate is 105%¹ at the end of 2011 (which means on average, there is at least one internet connection per home), and we also have the highest percentage of smart phone users in the world, relative to our population. It is a common sight to see people swiping at their mobile devices on buses and trains. From watching videos to playing online games, and even making friends on social networks, many young people in Singapore appear to be living in a 24/7 "always on" world of their own. As social networks increase in popularity and usage, many youth, especially those who are more introverted by nature, may find it easier to make friends behind the safety of the computer. They may fall into the habit of spending too much time on chat rooms, instant messaging services or dating websites, just to maintain a relationship, to the detriment of forming relationships in the real world. There is also increasing trends of addiction in the following areas among the youth: gaming, internet porn and social and cyber networking.

Sample AQ

Since its official launch in the island state in 1997, the Internet has since become a ubiquitous feature of Singapore life, permeating myriad aspects of our existence, redefining modes of communication and transforming the information landscape. In the passage, Emily Speight presents many benefits of the internet while cautioning the reader of its pitfalls. Her views are deeply applicable to a technologically connected society like Singapore, where citizens harness the internet for positive uses, but can equally likely succumb to its insidious drawbacks.

Speight writes that the internet has fostered a culture of connectedness and empowerment, where one can communicate with family, friends and peers unconstrained by time or distance. Indeed, with smartphones and phablets in tow, the average Singaporean can make use of a plethora of platforms – What’sapp, Skype, Tango, Facebook, and Instagram – to communicate with anyone in any part of the world, in a manner that is immediate, unfettered, more frequent and more efficient. Individuals are empowered to use online platforms for socially beneficial causes, as can be seen in Facebook pages such as Creative for Causes, which seeks to publicise various local charity organizations so that they can reach out to a larger pool of donors and volunteers. Social media movements such as #GivingTuesday also use the power of Instagram and Twitter to encourage businesses, non-profit organisations and individuals to engage in various acts of giving to the needy, or to support worthy causes.

While the internet can certainly facilitate communication and drive social causes, a closer analysis unravels a less rose-tinted reality. The internet has seen the development of short, sharp and quick messages by multi-tasking technology users who are all too fond of being engaged in multiple conversations at once, and who have arguably lost the art of being ‘present’ in real conversations. In fact, it is not uncommon to see a typical Singaporean family being so engrossed in technological gadgets, cocooned in their wired worlds, that they are unable to engage in active empathetic listening and meaningful conversation. The internet, as Speight herself acknowledges, can also become a tool of “enslavement” by creating unhealthy addictions, many of which are rife in Singapore. The online world teems with danger at every turn – pornography, online gaming and cyberbullying, to name a few. Statistics paint the grim picture of one in three secondary school students experiencing online bullying through social networks. Even more disconcerting is the fact that one in two Singaporean teenagers has watched sexually explicit materials, with some being as young as seven when they were first exposed to pornography. The dark ramifications of the cyber world extend beyond just the young, for gambling intervention groups have also seen the rise in online football betting, which is illegal in Singapore. It is without a doubt that the internet, as Speight herself observes, “caters to the base in human nature.”

Speight further notes that the rise of the internet has put privacy at risk as users readily give away their personal information on social media websites and online purchasing sites. The increased popularity of social networking sites such as Twitter, Instagram and Facebook has allowed users, especially the youth, to disclose personal information online, whether intentionally or unwittingly, from private photographs to one’s location, creating a pool of data that can easily be accessed and exploited by anyone from advertising agencies to online predators. Moreover, the proliferation of online networks has reconfigured our relationships, perhaps in deleterious ways. Speight highlights the decline of face-to-face encounters and true friendships built on ties of trust, giving way instead to the rise of “so-called friends” amassed in online networks. Indeed, the online world has offered individuals the promise of “friendships” merely a click away, and in Singapore, many have found themselves building meaningless friendships with strangers rather than strengthening existing relationships. In the worst scenarios, many have fallen to scams online as they end up trusting online friends whom they hardly know. According to the Singapore Police Force, there has been a rise in internet love scams as well as extortions in the first six months of 2014.

Where language and literacy are concerned, Speight also points out how the internet has created a generation that lacks the analytical ability to process and question information – readers who skim rather than delve without real engagement with content. While such a concern cannot be broadly applied to the entire generation, many of whom are internet-savvy individuals who exploit the internet’s vast resources to conduct in-depth research and consolidate different perspectives, there is undeniably

some truth in Speight's observation. The internet delivers a massive amount of information at the click of a button, much of it in small bytes with plenty of visuals, leaving very little incentive or space for critical reflection. The information presented is very persuasive and limited in scope and relies on the motivation of the young person to read widely and consider differing perspectives. However, this is not always apparent amongst the average Singapore teenager, who seems to lack the critical ability, or perhaps even the desire, to question the assumptions, as well as the authenticity of assertions online – skills that would help them to better navigate the often-murky world of the internet. Local statistics also highlight how, in extreme cases, students fall prey to messages promoting anorexia and self-harm – they are spurred to disordered eating by other chatroom users who recommend “green tea and no food” for the perceived problem of a “fat back” or are tempted to experiment with drugs through websites promoting ‘skunk,’ a potent strain of cannabis that can cause psychosis.

Speight also points out how the growing popularity of the Internet can lead to the demise of the world of print such as the traditional libraries, newspapers, bookshops and printed books. While some may argue that the rise of independent bookstores in cultural enclaves such as Singapore's Tiong Bahru attests to a thriving book-reading culture, the reality is that this only applies to a very niche community. The massive shut-downs of commercial book chains including Borders and Page One, suggests all too readily an erosion of interest in the printed word amongst Singaporeans. Singapore educators also quick to highlight how they observe fewer young adults and teenagers reading books for fun, as the distraction of smartphones and more visually stimulating entertainment have successfully steered their attention away from print media.

With a household broadband penetration rate of over 105% and at least one internet connection per home, it is undeniable that the internet has reinvented our lives dramatically, in both favourable and inimical ways. Speight ends on an optimistic note when she asserts that young people, at the end of the day, would assert greater control over the internet rather than be controlled by it. In spite of the possible quagmires that young people may fall into due to their oftentimes excessive internet usage, one can still find it plausible to believe that the Singaporean teenager would also emerge all the better after learning how to utilise the internet wisely to his or her long term advantage.